

perpetually, to create a transparent and accountable society. He is also engaged with NepalMap — a Web application that puts Nepal-related data at one's fingertips.

He says, "Both of these are based on open source software and are managed by volunteers to tackle the issue of data availability in Nepal. But 50 per cent of my task is to build and reach an audience, promoting openness through various kinds of events and workshops."

However, he has faced many challenges along the way. The biggest challenge was to maintain consistency, as open source is a place where the flow of contributors is never stable. Hence, managing the sustainability of the project and contributors at the same time is quite difficult, as it sometimes becomes time consuming with no guarantee of the output.

He did find ways to overcome these challenges, though. "Developing the habit of waiting patiently is very important if we want to build something successfully. It doesn't matter if you are alone — sometimes you may feel alone, but you have to keep working daily if you are dedicated to keeping the momentum alive."

A focus on gender, environment, disaster response, and post-pandemic economy recovery

Balami says he did not start Open Knowledge Nepal, but has led it under the guidance of his mentor Prakash Neupane with the help of his colleagues, who believe in the philosophy of openness. He used to volunteer for Open Knowledge Nepal and help with its projects and activities. Looking at his contribution, he was given the responsibility of leading the organisation.

"We at Open Knowledge Nepal aim to make sure that everyone has free and open access to key information, empowering them to make decisions about their own lives based on the information that wasn't available before. We believe that openness of data is powerful in order to have a participatory government with civil society, eventually leading to sustainable development. We achieve this by research, advocacy, training, workshops, and developing tools related to open knowledge," adds Balami.

Open Knowledge Nepal works in the interdisciplinary field of knowledge, and has played a pioneering role in creating and driving forward open data and open knowledge in Nepal. It has encouraged and supported governments, civil societies and researchers to make their data open. Where people needed skills, they have been provided with the training. Where people needed tools, Open Knowledge Nepal made them, says Balami.

"Our focus nowadays is on the fields of gender, environment, disaster response, and post-pandemic economy recovery by the effective use of data and technology," he comments.

With a rich experience in FOSS, Balami has some advice for newbies too. He says, "Start, don't procrastinate. Today is always the right time to start. That's the only advice I can give — don't waste time procrastinating, and start contributing and exploring potential contribution activities, because in the FOSS space, it is very easy to find mentors who will guide you throughout the journey."

He feels that skillsets are something that we can develop by learning and doing. But if one wants

to be successful, having the enthusiasm of learning new things continuously is very important.

Nepal still has a long way to go

So how is Nepal performing in the open source ecosystem? Balami says, "It is evolving but still has a long way to go in the field of information and technology. The open source ecosystem is evolving with it, and the people with good digital literacy have clearly understood the value of open source — which is why it has become a part of the technological life of many organisations and individuals."

He feels that India is the regional hub, with a huge human and technological resource base, and that its performance in the open source space has always been great as a result.

Digital knowledge creates power for the many, not the few

He states, "Last year when I travelled to Singapore to speak at FOSS ASIA, I got an opportunity to interact with many techies, and most of the hackathons and workshops were dominated by Indian developers. Most importantly, open source is evolving in the rural areas of India, which is very good. One of my mentees from the Mozilla Open Leaders programme comes from a rural college of India, and the activities they do and the enthusiasm they carry always inspire me."

Finally, when asked about the future of open source, Balami says, "The future is open by default." This is because without openness and open source it is impossible to create anything innovative, especially in the field of technology. He feels that we need to create a world where digital knowledge creates power for the many, not the few. **END** 

 By: Sreejani Bhattacharya

The author is a tech correspondent at OSFY.